

6

Disagreement and Error

I claim to have refuted, in the last four chapters, four of the five theories in metaethics: non-cognitivism, subjectivism, naturalism, and nihilism. As is usual in philosophy, the 'refutations' are provisional: those theories have been shown to face grave problems that justify rejecting them as long as any plausible alternative exists. Ethical intuitionism is the remaining alternative. But the received view in the field has long been that intuitionism is a hopelessly naive idea that can be dismissed in a few sentences. 'I propose to ignore this theory', writes Brandt of a related thesis; but most authors simply ignore it with no prior announcement. Ethics textbooks now contain one-paragraph 'refutations' of the doctrine, if they discuss it at all. All of this evidences the esteem in which intuitionism is held these days.¹ So, the naive onlooker might conclude, contemporary philosophers must know some obvious and decisive objections to the theory. What are they?

Most experts take the existence of moral disagreement and error as the main reason for rejecting intuitionism. There are three versions of the argument. One is that the occurrence of disagreement entails that morality is not objective. Another is that intuitionists cannot plausibly *explain* disagreement or error. The last is that intuitionists have no method of *resolving* disagreements.

Before elaborating these arguments, let us review the phenomenon their proponents have in mind.

6.1 The prevalence of moral disagreement

There are three main kinds of moral disagreement:

First, disagreements among cultures. Members of a tribe in New Guinea used to eat the brains of dead kinswomen, as part of their mourning ceremonies. Aztec priests used to perform human sacrifices, cutting out the still-beating hearts of victims to feed them to the sun god. Many societies, including our own before the last century, have routinely practiced slavery. All of these practices horrify modern Western observers, yet other societies have found them acceptable, or even obligatory.²

Second, popular disagreements within our society. Some believe that abortion is murder and is therefore among the worst crimes one can commit; others believe it is not wrong at all. Some believe that justice demands capital punishment for heinous criminals; others consider capital punishment uncivilized and unjust. Some think that affirmative action is needed to make reparations for past injustices; others think it adds to the injustice.

Third, theoretical disagreements of philosophers. Some philosophers think the right action is always the one with the best consequences; others say that the ends don't justify the means, and that some kinds of action are wrong even if they produce the best consequences. Some philosophers maintain that the sole good in life is pleasure; others think there are many goods. Some philosophers hold that we ought to value others' interests just as much as our own; others say we are beholden to none but ourselves.

These are a few of the many examples that could be given. They paint a picture of strong, fundamental disagreements as the norm in moral matters. But this is misleading for two reasons. First, many of these disagreements are not *fundamentally* moral disagreements, but instead turn on differences in the (non-moral) circumstances people find themselves in, or believe themselves to be in. To borrow one of James Rachels' examples, it initially seems that the Eskimos, in their acceptance of infanticide, have very different values from us. But their acceptance of infanticide is explained by the harsh conditions under which they live, in which food is in short supply. In these conditions, families may be unable to provide for all infants, and attempting to do so may threaten the survival of others. Thus, in their circumstances, infanticide makes sense; it need not indicate a lesser respect for life on the part of Eskimos, nor fundamentally different values from ours.³ To take another example, the practice of human sacrifice had roots in religious beliefs. Primitive peoples

thought the gods demanded sacrifice. The Aztecs believed the sun would literally stop shining if human sacrifices were not performed; furthermore, they believed the souls of sacrificial victims went to the best afterlife, so the priests were actually doing them a favor. Our society rejects human sacrifice because we reject those beliefs, not because we have fundamentally different values.

Many moral disputes within our society have non-moral roots. Pro-life and pro-choice activists may differ over such questions as whether fetuses are sentient, whether they have souls, and whether God forbids abortion. Disagreements about affirmative action may involve disagreements about the causes of economic inequalities among races. I do not say this accounts for all moral disagreements, but it reduces the prevalence and importance of the disagreements that can be regarded as fundamentally moral.

A second reason why the examples of disagreement are misleading is that they are deliberately selected from a much greater number of moral issues about which there is generally agreement. The cases of abortion, capital punishment, and affirmative action have not been randomly selected from all moral issues; they are selected for attention because they are among the most notorious subjects of controversy. The proponent of the argument from disagreement does not draw our attention to *paradigmatic* instances of murder—say, killing a store owner during an armed robbery so that one cannot later be identified. Nor does he raise the issue of the wrongness of indiscriminate lying, stealing, and breaking of promises. Those things are closer to the core of our moral code, but they do not attract attention or become subjects of public discussion. Public discourse naturally focuses instead on areas of disagreement. This gives us an exaggerated impression of the importance of such disagreement.

The disagreements of philosophers too are somewhat exaggerated. Philosophers agree on paradigm cases of wrongful actions—killing people for fun, torture, typical cases of theft. Moral philosophers argue with one another largely by appealing to hypothetical cases about which we generally have the same intuitions. Indeed, if we did not agree on most cases, we could have no interesting discussion—we might not even understand one another's words, since if your conception of the good bears no resemblance to mine, then I will not understand your words as referring to goodness at all, nor can I credit you with any rational arguments on the subject. What philosophers disagree about is what *account* is to be given of the paradigm cases. For example, they may differ over whether murder is wrong because it violates a right to life, or because it decreases the total amount of value in the world.

None of this is to deny the existence of important disagreements about values. It is only to say that these disagreements are less prevalent than is sometimes thought, and that they take place against a backdrop of substantial moral agreement.

6.2 The idiot's veto

The first version of the argument from disagreement claims that the existence of disagreement about morality is incompatible with morality's being 'objective'.⁴ I shall not dwell on this argument long, since few philosophers would be guilty of advancing it. The argument's premise is that a claim is 'objectively' true only if everyone agrees or would agree with it (perhaps after hearing the arguments for it).

This premise introduces what I call an 'idiot's veto'. The Idiot's Veto is the principle that one can bar any (would-be) fact from the realm of objectivity merely by failing to apprehend it. In effect, the premise grants individuals with limited cognitive abilities or stubbornly skeptical dispositions a *veto power* over any would-be objective truth. Thus, suppose a physics teacher encounters a student who refuses to accept the Second Law of Thermodynamics (such individuals are the source of the perennial efforts to design 'perpetual motion machines'). According to the Idiot's Veto, this would rule out the objectivity of the Second Law of Thermodynamics.

No interesting sense of 'objective' makes that true. Take the definition according to which objectivity is a matter of independence from observers. On this interpretation, the Idiot's Veto claims that for a thing to exist independently of observers, everyone must agree that it exists. This is a *non sequitur*. The definition of objectivity says nothing about agreement.

A second conception takes an 'objective' truth to be one that has been or can be *proven*. On this interpretation, the Idiot's Veto maintains that if at least one person would not agree with *x*, then *x* has not been proven. But on any ordinary understanding of 'proof', it is possible for a person to not accept the conclusion of a proof—whether through lack of understanding, mistake, bias, or what have you—and their failure to believe that conclusion does not invalidate the proof. A proof is, roughly, an argument with no flaws; someone's mere failure to accept the conclusion of an argument does not constitute a flaw in the argument.

Of course, one could simply *stipulate* that 'objective' mean 'would be agreed to by everyone'. But this would deprive the argument of any philosophical interest. Not only would this be a misleading use

of the term, but it would be a use according to which there may well be no proposition whatever that is 'objective'. The interest of the debate about moral objectivity comes from the anti-realists' view that ethics differs in some crucial way from other, more 'objective' fields such as physics and mathematics. The Idiot's Veto identifies no such difference. It implies that the Second Law of Thermodynamics is not objective, as we have seen. It implies that the Theory of Evolution is not objectively true, since Creationists reject it. And it implies that the very existence of the material world is not objective, since Bishop Berkeley rejected it.

To give this version of the Argument from Disagreement any plausibility, we must qualify its premise. Perhaps the premise should be that if some *fully rational, fully informed* person would not agree with a claim, then the claim lacks objectivity.⁵ But rational and informed people still make mistakes. One who makes a miscalculation, or who misunderstands or fails to understand a concept, is not thereby irrational, misinformed, or uninformed. Presumably, someone's making an error about *x* does not refute *x*'s objectivity in any interesting sense, so the premise needs to be qualified again. We may also add a qualification concerning bias, since failure to agree with *x* due to bias should not impugn *x*'s objectivity. Our new version of the premise (no longer an Idiot's Veto) is this: If some fully rational, informed, and unbiased person, who correctly and fully understands *x* and makes no mistakes, would not agree with *x*, then *x* is not objectively true.

Perhaps the premise in this latest version is correct. But now the problem is that of showing that there are any moral disagreements of the relevant kind. While we can readily observe disagreements about moral issues, few if any humans are completely rational, informed, or unbiased. And how shall we establish that both parties to a disagreement correctly and fully understand the issue and have made no mistakes? There are many ways in which humans can make mistakes, most of which are common in moral matters, as we see in the next section.

6.3 Can intuitionists explain disagreement?

The second version of the Argument from Disagreement asserts that the evidence of moral disagreement strongly favors anti-realism over intuitionism, because anti-realists are better able to explain disagreement than intuitionists are. Anti-realists understand inter-cultural disagreements as being due to differing forms of life, together with the absence of any facts determining the 'correct' form of life. They

understand interpersonal disagreements as arising from differing personal preferences, together with the absence of any facts determining the 'correct' preferences. The intuitionist, in contrast, must say people are subject to widespread error, but he has no account of why this would be so. In short:

1. There is widespread disagreement about values.
2. If intuitionism were true, there (probably) would not be widespread disagreement about values.
3. Therefore (probably), intuitionism is false.⁶

6.3.1 The caricature

How is intuitionism supposed to preclude the possibility of widespread error? Here is one popular answer; I call it 'the Caricature':

Caricature Intuitionists hold: (i) All moral questions can be resolved by *direct* appeal to intuition. There is no place for reasoning or any other process of investigation in moral philosophy. (ii) Intuition is infallible. And (iii) everyone knows these things. It follows that everyone can immediately obtain an answer to any moral question by simply consulting his intuition. These answers must all agree, since intuition is infallible. And since everyone knows these facts, no one will ever form a moral belief by any other means. So everyone will agree.⁷

If the history of philosophy has seen a less charitable misreading of a major philosophical position, I do not know what it is. I know of no one who has ever held the views there attributed to intuitionism. Intuitionists have repeatedly denied the claim of infallibility in particular.⁸ Nowell-Smith supports the attribution with the following quotation from the eighteenth-century intuitionist Samuel Clarke:

These things are so notoriously plain and self-evident, that nothing but the extremist stupidity of mind, corruption of manners or perversity of spirit can possibly make any man entertain the least doubt concerning them.⁹

Nowell-Smith produces this quotation while discussing the intuitionist's alleged inability to accommodate moral disagreement; he neglects to inform his readers what 'these things' refers to in the passage, leaving them perhaps to infer that it refers to all moral

truths. In fact, Clarke is referring to a specific series of moral principles that he has listed, principles such as the following:

[I]n Men's dealing and conversing one with another, 'tis undeniably more Fit . . . that all Men should endeavour to promote universal good and welfare of All, than that Men should be continually contriving the ruin and destruction of All.¹⁰

While there are important moral matters that people disagree over, the above principle is not among them. The only of Clarke's examples that are at all controversial are those concerning obligations of and to God, where the source of controversy is metaphysical, rather than ethical. Thus, the quoted passage does not justify attributing to Clarke the view that we are infallible about all moral matters—to say nothing of other intuitionists.

In any event, if anyone has held the absurdly strong and simplistic views described in the Caricature, I do not.

6.3.2 The prevalence of non-moral disagreement

Perhaps I have been unkind to the argument from disagreement. A more subtle version holds, not that intuitionism rules out any moral disagreement, but that intuitionism *renders improbable* disagreements *of the kind and number* that we find in moral philosophy. Disagreements in moral philosophy are very widespread, are often apparently unresolvable, and sometimes concern fundamental questions of the sort that we would expect intuition to speak to. It is this specific pattern of disagreement that the intuitionist allegedly cannot explain. Though they reject infallibility, presumably intuitionists at least believe that intuition is generally reliable at producing correct beliefs; otherwise, it could hardly account for moral knowledge. But the observed pattern of moral disagreement impugns the reliability of moral intuition and moral reasoning, since if we had available a reliable method of identifying moral truths, there should be relatively few disagreements, and disagreements should frequently be resolved by application of that method.¹¹

I disagree. I don't think the availability of moral knowledge is incompatible with frequent and persistent moral disagreements. This subsection brings out the first part of my case for this: the prevalence of non-moral disagreements with the same problematic features as moral disagreements. Consider some examples:

1. Who shot JFK? Forty years after the assassination, many remain *convinced* that there was a conspiracy, possibly involving Cubans,

the mafia, or the CIA. Others are equally certain that a lone gunman, Lee Harvey Oswald, was responsible.

2. What is the best football team in America?
3. How should quantum mechanics be interpreted? Einstein and Bohr debated whether the formalism of quantum mechanics was complete, without issue. To this day, there remain multiple interpretations of quantum mechanics, each with their own advocates.
4. What are the actual practices of other cultures? Anthropologists for decades took there to have been many cultures in which cannibalism was common. In 1979, William Arens argued that this was a myth, that in fact no culture ever practiced widespread cannibalism. Anthropologists disagreed sharply in their assessments of Arens' work. Similarly, a heated debate arose when in 1983 Derek Freeman purported to show that Margaret Mead's famous account of life in Samoa was entirely inaccurate. Both controversies aroused strong emotions and continue to this day.¹²
5. What are the economic effects of government social programs? Some think they have been essential in ameliorating the great poverty and suffering that would otherwise be the lot of the lower classes in a capitalist country. Others think those same programs actually *harm* the poor.¹³
6. What religion, if any, is correct? We've had millennia to think about it, and we haven't even agreed on whether there is a God, let alone what He wants.
7. Are there paranormal phenomena? I suspect most readers will answer no. But a quarter of Americans believe in astrology, half believe in ESP, and a quarter believe they have had a telepathic experience.¹⁴
8. What causes illness? The same cultures that have very different moral beliefs from ours also accept very different answers to this question. Many think illnesses can be caused magically by others' ill will. Western society accepted for centuries that diseases were caused by imbalances of the body's four humors.

Many more examples could be given. The disagreements in examples 1–7 have the following features:

- i) They are widespread among people who have an opinion about the issues; it isn't just a few people going against a consensus.
- ii) They are apparently unresolvable. Anyone who thinks they can resolve who shot JFK by 'just going in and looking at the facts' is invited to try. You may well figure out 'the answer' (by your

lights), but only the uninitiated will imagine they have a chance of convincing the other side(s).

iii) They concern objective, non-evaluative facts. Indeed, such questions as who shot JFK and whether a particular culture practiced cannibalism are *paradigms* of objective questions.

In the case of example 8, there was an agreed upon answer in our society for several centuries, but this answer was completely wrong.

I have listed a number of examples to illustrate the scope of human disagreement. People disagree about historical events, about apparently straightforward matters of empirical fact, about things allegedly established by science, about the interpretation of accepted theories, and about many philosophical matters, among other things. Even when we agree, that is no guarantee of our being right, as example 8 shows. I have, admittedly, given a partial view of our intellectual life: I have intentionally selected notable cases of strong and persistent disagreements. But then, the anti-realist has done likewise for the moral realm in calling forth such examples as abortion and capital punishment.

Persistent non-moral disagreements are common. Yet virtually no one takes this to refute the possibility of knowledge in such fields as history, anthropology, and economics. I suspect few would draw even the slightly skeptical conclusion that we cannot gain knowledge concerning the specific issues about which we disagree (even if we haven't yet done so). How, then, is moral disagreement supposed to refute the possibility of moral knowledge?

Perhaps there is something especially problematic about disagreements in areas where knowledge depends on *intuitions*, as opposed to areas where knowledge depends on other means, such as observation and scientific reasoning. If there is, I have no idea what it is. Intuitionists need not and do not maintain that knowledge based on intuition is *superior* to empirical knowledge; they need not take reasoning based on moral intuitions to be more reliable than science, for example. Opponents of intuitionism are simply applying an epistemological double standard: If scientific and other empirical reasoning fails to produce agreement in many cases, yet this does not invalidate it as a source of knowledge, then why should intuition's similar failure to produce agreement invalidate *it* as a source of knowledge?

Perhaps the problem is that in the case of moral philosophy, we have many disputes all within the same subject matter, whereas the non-moral disputes are isolated instances distributed across many different subjects. But this is not so. There are numerous disputes on

the subject of religion, even its non-moral claims; all branches of philosophy; sports, particularly the merits of various players and teams and what people 'should' do (in a non-moral sense) at various points in a game; the relative abilities of specific individuals one may know (for example, is Sally smarter than me?); and everything bearing on politics, again including non-moral questions. Yet none of these are areas in which objective facts don't exist, nor in which we lack cognitive faculties capable of apprehending facts of that kind.

6.3.3 A menagerie of error

What is surprising about disagreement, such that it calls for special explanation? Beliefs, we think, aim at the truth. If people *attain* the truth, then they will agree with each other. So widespread disagreement entails widespread error, even though we are ostensibly trying to avoid error. Why don't we just stop using the unreliable belief-forming methods that lead us into disagreements? Why don't we just sit down, taking our logic and critical thinking textbooks in hand, and figure out who is making the bad arguments?

The preceding questions rest on naive assumptions. While beliefs in some sense aim at the truth, people's beliefs may gratify many other passions besides the rational hankering after the truth. Nor do the canons of logic and critical thinking algorithmically determine what is and isn't a bad argument. People seldom satisfy ideal conditions for reasoning, and even the best of cognitive conditions do not render humans infallible. The causes of our beliefs can be highly complex and largely hidden from us. We often cannot articulate some of the reasons for our beliefs. The intuitionist can no more produce an algorithm for computing the correct moral theory than we can produce a general algorithm for computing correct empirical theories.

Critics have charged that the intuitionist has available no account of moral error other than 'blindness', stupidity, or deliberate mendacity.¹⁵ To better assess this charge, let us review some of the sources of error in general:

1. *Bias*: People who are biased are moved by emotions and desires, other than the desire to have true beliefs and avoid false ones, to view some claims favorably and others unfavorably. In other words, there are some things we *want* to believe, and others we want not to believe. Often, we want to believe what is in our interests to believe, or to convince others of; what we would like to be true; what would be in the interests of the social group with which we identify to believe; and what coheres with the self-

image we want to maintain. These are just some of the possible biases we may suffer from.¹⁶

2. *Miscalculation*: While performing a calculation, I forget to carry a '1', resulting in an incorrect answer. If no one points it out to me, I may never realize my error. I may fully understand the mathematical principles involved in the problem; be rational, unbiased, and intelligent; and yet still make a mistake.
3. *Confusion*: This involves failure to distinguish two superficially similar things. For example, the student who thinks that because we cannot talk about anything without using language, we cannot talk about the language-independent world, is committing a confusion.
4. *Misunderstanding and lack of understanding*: Concepts and theories can be misunderstood. A student who thinks that chaos theory makes room for free will suffers from a lack of understanding of the concept of chaos and perhaps of free will. The philosopher who finds intuitionism absurd because it makes no room for moral debate suffers from a misunderstanding of the theory.
5. *Oversight*: People may fail to notice relevant considerations, including some of the implications of their statements. Someone asks me whether I think two solid objects can overlap in space. I answer 'No', based on my immediate impression—overlooking such examples as my hand and my body, or a statue and the mass of clay of which it is composed. Relatedly, people may exercise *selective attention*, that is, they may attend to only some of the relevant features of a situation, whether because of bias or simply because the situation is too complex to take everything in at once.
6. *Hasty judgments*: People often make a judgment based on an initial appearance, when longer, more careful thought would have resulted in a different judgment.
7. *False or incomplete information*: Sometimes people do not know all the facts that are relevant to making a judgment, and sometimes they make mistaken assumptions. For instance, two people arguing about gun control may have received radically different information, one by consulting NRA literature, the other by consulting literature from Handgun Control, Inc. Some of their information may be false, while neither has complete information.
8. *Unarticulated assumptions*: Imagine two people arguing about whether abortion should be legal. One assumes that they are arguing about whether abortion should *ever* be allowed, while the other assumes they are arguing about whether it should *always* be

- allowed. Or perhaps neither of them really knows which of these questions, if either, they intend to discuss.
9. *Stubbornness*: People may simply refuse to reconsider old beliefs, even when new, relevant evidence appears.
 10. *Fallacies*: These are illusions of reason—forms of reasoning that may superficially appear cogent but in fact are not; for example, equivocation, affirming the consequent, argument ad hominem. Especially important is misplaced trust in authority: people may believe a thing because others—parents, religious leaders, reporters, or other members of their society—have asserted it. But those others may not have known what they were talking about.
 11. *Forgetfulness*: People may forget or simply not notice their own reasons for holding a belief, and they may forget other relevant evidence. In this case, they are in a poor position to recognize when the belief has been undermined.
 12. *Intrinsic difficulty of issues*: Some issues, such as those that are particularly abstract or complex, are more difficult to grasp clearly and make judgments about than others.
 13. *Inarticulate evidence*: Sometimes we have grounds for belief that we cannot articulate. Suppose a friend has been accused of embezzling money from her company. Because I know her well, I know she would not do such a thing. But I could not *prove* this to a third party. This sort of inarticulate evidence can cause disagreement.
 14. *Mental defects*: Last and perhaps least, a few people lack cognitive capacities that most others have, or have cognitive capacities whose functioning is seriously distorted, as in the case of schizophrenics, autists, and psychopaths. Though a paranoid schizophrenic may otherwise appear a competent reasoner, you will have no luck reasoning him out of his delusions.

These sources of error are not all independent of each other; some overlap and some influence others.

I cannot claim completeness for my menagerie of error; perhaps there are further sources of error I have overlooked. Given the multitude of ways human beings can go wrong, why do anti-realists think that moral disagreement must be explained by a shortage of objective facts? All of the above sources of error and disagreement operate in non-moral matters whose objectivity is undisputed; there is no obvious reason why they should not also operate in moral matters.

6.3.4 Disagreement is predictable

Proponents of the argument from disagreement, all too eager in their rejections of intuitionism, have neglected to justify the crucial second premise of their argument—

2. If intuitionism were true, there would not be widespread disagreement about values.

As we have seen, there are many ways human beings can go wrong, and there are many persistent disagreements about objective, in principle knowable facts. In light of this, we have no obvious grounds for predicting that there would not be widespread disputes about values.

But now I want to say something stronger: I think that we *have* obvious grounds for predicting that there *would* be widespread disputes about values, even if intuitionism were true. This requires looking at the kinds of cases in which disagreement and error are common, in general. There are at least four kinds of cases to consider.

First: Disagreement and error are common where there are strong and frequent biases. Bias is particularly important, since it increases the frequency and seriousness of most other kinds of errors, such as oversight, misunderstanding, forgetfulness, and so on. It probably plays a major role in the disagreements listed in section 6.3.2. Here are some common sources of bias, all of which may affect moral questions:

Self-interest: It would be in my interests, for example, to believe that the things I want to do are morally acceptable, and that the things I want others to do are obligatory. It would be even more clearly in my interests to convince others of these things.

Wishful thinking: I would like it to be true that the world is just; that the way things actually are, is good; that I and my social group are especially praiseworthy; that our practices are justified.

Group interests: It would be in the interests of my social group to believe that we are superior to other groups, that the things we want to do are justified, and so forth.

Self-image: Sometimes the self-images we want to construct affect what beliefs we adopt. If I wish to portray myself as compassionate and forgiving, I may want to reject capital punishment; but if

I prefer to portray myself as tough and uncompromising, then I may want to embrace capital punishment.

Second: Disagreement and error are common in areas where people defer to their cultures' traditions. Cultural traditions are a notoriously unreliable source of information. The cultures with the surprising moral beliefs, which are supposed to make us doubt the reality of moral facts, also have a host of surprising non-moral beliefs—about such things as the causes of disease, the structure of the cosmos, human history, and the workings of the physical world—that we know, scientifically, to be false.

Third: Disagreement and error are common in areas where people defer to religion, another unreliable source of information. In section 3.4, I mentioned some false moral beliefs supported by the Bible. Here are some false factual beliefs also apparently supported by the Bible:

Rabbits chew cud. (*Deuteronomy* 14:6–7)

Some insects are four-legged. (*Leviticus* 11:20–22)

The Earth is flat. (*Matthew* 4:8)

$\pi = 3$. (*1 Kings* 7:23)

The Earth is stationary and rests on a foundation. (*Psalms* 104:5)

The Earth is about 6000 years old. (Allegedly supported by various parts of the Bible.¹⁷)

Fourth: Disagreement is common in all areas of philosophy. For centuries, philosophers have disagreed about such things as God, free will, universals, *a priori* knowledge, and the nature of the mind, to name a few. The level of disagreement in ethics is no greater than that found in metaphysics, epistemology, philosophy of mind, or philosophy of language.¹⁸

On all four counts, we should expect moral issues to be especially prone to disagreement. My response to the major premise of the argument from disagreement, then, is this: even if there were objective moral truths and we had available ways of knowing them, widespread, strong, and persistent disagreements could still be expected. No anti-realist assumption is required to predict the phenomenon.

6.4 Can intuitionists resolve disagreements?

The final version of the Argument from Disagreement goes something like this:

1. Intuitionism provides no way of resolving moral disagreements.
2. If a metaethical theory provides no way of resolving moral disagreements, then it is false.
3. Therefore, intuitionism is false.

Typically, only premise (1) is stated explicitly. Premise (2) is also needed, but its justification remains obscure.

6.4.1 Hypothetical disagreements

How should we interpret (1)—which disagreements is the intuitionist to be castigated for his inability to resolve? For some critics, the complaint seems to be that the intuitionist has no way to resolve certain *hypothetical* disagreements. Thus, Nowell-Smith stipulates a case in which someone disagrees with us about a moral issue and will not accept any premise we might use to support our view. In such a case, he says, there is no way to resolve the dispute through reasoning.¹⁹ While he is undoubtedly right about this, this hardly points up a flaw in intuitionism. *No one* can provide a way of rationally resolving *any* kind of dispute if we stipulate that each party refuses to accept any premises that the other party might use. How is this supposed to be a problem?

6.4.2 Controversial moral questions

Perhaps the complaint is that there are some *actual* disagreements that the intuitionist can give us no way to resolve, such as the disputes over abortion, capital punishment, and affirmative action. While this is plausible, it is at least as plausible to think that no one *else* can provide a way of resolving such disputes either. Why should we think that a metaethical theory can only be true if it provides a way of resolving all disputes? Perhaps this is supposed to be an adequacy condition only for *realist* theories, but even then it remains unmotivated. Suppose I have just given a philosophical theory according to which there are objective facts about physical objects, and all our knowledge of such facts derives from perception. Would the following be a fair objection: 'You haven't provided a way of settling who shot JFK. Therefore, your theory is wrong'?

6.4.3 Foundational moral controversies

Perhaps the complaint is that some disagreements about *foundational* moral claims—moral claims that do not depend on other beliefs—cannot be resolved. The dispute about JFK concerns beliefs that depend on reasoning, not foundational beliefs, so it is not analogous.

If this is the argument, we should first note that foundational

moral disputes are relatively rare; the disputes about abortion and affirmative action are not instances, since our beliefs about those issues depend on further beliefs. For example, most who think abortion is wrong think so because they believe that fetuses are people, that it is generally wrong to kill persons, and that abortion kills fetuses. Moreover, the literature is replete with examples of rational moral arguments concerning abortion and other notorious matters of controversy, showing that we need not throw up our hands when confronted with such disputes.²⁰ Although Ayer claims that foundational moral disagreements are 'notorious', he provides no examples. The most plausible examples are things that for the most part, only philosophers argue about, such as whether we ought to weigh other people's interests equally with our own, or whether the action with the best consequences is always right.

Second, as long as our foundationalism is of a moderate form, it is not impossible to reason about intuitive moral principles. We may hold even intuitive moral principles open to revision in the light of further evidence. The examples given in the previous paragraph are principles we have intuitions about, but moral philosophers have hardly given up reasoning about them. I shall return to this point in the following section.²¹

Third, while the inability to resolve disputes is a serious *practical* problem, it is simply unclear how it is supposed to constitute *evidence* that the theory of intuitionism is *false*.

Fourth, it is unclear why reasoning is not subjected to the same demands as other means of cognition. There are many apparently unresolvable disputes about beliefs that depend on reasoning, but that does not convince us that reasoning is not a legitimate means of cognition. So why would apparently unresolvable disputes about beliefs that depend on intuition convince us that intuition is not a legitimate means of cognition? Perhaps the argument presupposes that we *have* straightforward ways of determining, in all cases, whether a piece of reasoning is cogent. But of course that is false. There is no generally accepted, comprehensive, and useful set of rules for what counts as evidence for what. That is what such examples as the JFK dispute illustrate: no one can establish, in a way that all intelligent parties would agree with, whether the available evidence supports a conspiracy theory.

Finally, imagine a dispute about a non-intuitive, foundational claim. Two witnesses at a trial give different versions of events, both claiming to have *seen* what they report. This sort of case is not unusual. Both witnesses may give every known sign of sincerely believing what they say.²² Is it the job of a philosophical theory of

perception to provide a way to resolve that dispute? If I cannot do so, is my theory of perception—say, my claim that the physical world is objective, or my claim that perception is a legitimate source of knowledge—thereby refuted? If not, then how would the failure to resolve some moral disputes refute either the existence of objective values, or the claim that ethical intuition is a legitimate means of cognition?

6.4.4 Disputes in general

Some charge that intuitionists have no way to resolve *any* disputes, or at least not any disputes about intuitions.²³ Faced with disagreement, intuitionists must immediately break out the clubs and start hitting people over the head.²⁴ Unlike the others, this charge would identify a serious flaw in intuitionism, since in fact some disputes *are* resolvable. But the charge is false.

Faced with a disagreement, an intuitionist may, among other things, attempt to determine whether one of the common causes of error discussed in section 6.3.3 is operative, and to remedy the situation if it is. He may investigate such questions as whether one party is biased; whether there are misunderstandings or confusions about some of the concepts or views involved in the debate; whether one party has made a hasty judgment or oversight; whether either party has false or incomplete information; and so on. Any of these problems could adversely affect one's intuitive judgments. In addition, some intuitions may turn out to depend (causally) on further beliefs in ways one was not initially aware of. This can sometimes be brought out by considering further hypothetical scenarios ('Would you still say *x* was wrong if *p* were the case?'), and these further beliefs can then be examined.

The problem of bias is the most troubling one. Although bias is pervasive in intellectual life, accusations of bias rarely advance discussion. They are more likely to lead to each side's searching for arguments to show that the other side is more biased, and these arguments are likely to be assessed with at least as much bias as the original moral issue. For this reason, there may be little we can do about the biases of others. But we can try to counter our own biases. Merely identifying a bias goes a great distance towards counteracting it. When approaching a moral issue, we should think about whether we are subject to the sorts of biases previously discussed. Along these lines, we should ask whether we hold the moral beliefs that we do because of our culture or religion, and if so, we should be suspicious of those beliefs. A belief's being endorsed by our culture or religion is not evidence that it is false, but it is evidence that our belief is

unreliable, that we would likely hold the belief whether it was true or not.

An example from Peter Singer illustrates the point. After defending the permissibility of abortion, Singer confronts the charge that his arguments cannot distinguish between fetuses and newborn infants and thus imply that infanticide is also permissible in many cases (roughly, because newborn infants have no more sophisticated mental capacities than fetuses). He responds, in part, by informing the reader that many societies have considered infanticide acceptable and even obligatory in certain cases. Plato, Aristotle, and Seneca all recommended the killing of deformed infants. What is Singer's point here? Is he making an appeal to authority, to defend infanticide? No; his point is that our horror at the thought of killing infants is probably more a product of our particular culture (particularly, he thinks, of Christianity) than of the objective facts about infants. He also suggests that a good part of the cause of our belief is the cuteness of infants, which is morally irrelevant.²⁵

I make no attempt to resolve the disputes about abortion and infanticide. My aim is simply to illustrate the importance of looking beyond one's culture. Singer is correct to urge that the culture-specific nature of beliefs about infanticide diminishes their authority.

Reducing bias is only part of a reasonable strategy for ameliorating moral disagreement. Moral arguments must also play a major role in the effort to resolve disputes, even disputes about intuitive principles. Philosophers may reason with one another about a moral principle by, for example, considering how well it coheres with other moral principles; looking for previously unnoticed consequences of the principle; considering how it applies to specific situations about which we have intuitions; drawing analogies between the principle and other principles that we accept or reject; and looking for plausible general constraints on moral theories (for instance: 'A moral theory should make it understandable how people can be motivated by the good' or, 'A moral theory should imply that when A is better than B and B is better than C, A is better than C').²⁶ Philosophers have far from given up on resolving moral issues, though we recognize that the project is a long-term one.²⁷ Intuitionists will naturally embrace all or nearly all of the current methods of normative ethics. In light of this, the majority of ethicists cannot reject intuitionism on the grounds that it fails to license a reasonable approach to disputed moral questions.

Why might intuitionism be thought to preclude reasoning about intuitions? It might be thought that *foundationalists* cannot allow reasoning about foundational beliefs. But this is a misunderstanding.

A foundational belief is defined as one that *does not need* a reason in order to be justified to some degree; it is not defined as a belief that *cannot have* a reason. Moreover, most foundationalists embrace the notion of *prima facie* justification discussed in section 5.1 above. My principle of Phenomenal Conservatism is a case in point: it holds only that appearances are rationally presumed true, until evidence of their falsity or unreliability appears. Intuitionists should allow that intuitive justification for a moral belief can be defeated, either because of tensions with other moral beliefs (one's own or others'), or because of empirical evidence of its unreliability (for example, evidence of bias). So intuitionists seem to have at least as good prospects for resolving disputes as anyone in moral philosophy.

You might feel some justified skepticism about the prospects for resolving disagreements by the means I have suggested. Few people, whatever they may say, will conscientiously work to root out their own biases. Most will continue to unreflectively defer to their culture and religion. Even moral philosophers will likely continue, for the most part, to rationalize their favored theories. For at least this reason, moral disagreement is here to stay. This reveals a grievous flaw in human nature. But it reveals no flaw in ethical intuitionism.

6.5 The self-refutation problem

The argument from disagreement is double-edged: it can be turned against the views of its proponents as easily as it can be turned against intuitionism. To begin with, notice that proponents of other metaethical positions take their own views to be objectively true. In asserting their theories about the nature of moral claims, they are not purporting merely to express or describe their emotions, for example; they are purporting to state a fact that we have adequate grounds for believing (if there are no moral facts, it is a [non-moral] fact that there are no moral facts). But if the argument from disagreement is sound, then it refutes itself, since many people do not agree with the argument from disagreement. The argument would likewise refute any metaethical position, due to the nature of disagreement in metaethics. Recall the three versions of the argument from disagreement:

- a) *The Idiot's Veto*: If someone's disagreeing with a claim, in general, prevents that claim from being objectively true, then the disagreements in metaethics prevent any metaethical view from being objectively true. Similarly, some people reject the argument from disagreement, so it cannot be objectively correct.

b) *The problem of explaining disagreement:* The disagreement over metaethical theories is at least as widespread and persistent as that over ethical theories. Should we explain this by denying the existence of any correct metaethical theory? Similarly, there is no general agreement on whether the argument from disagreement is correct; does this suggest that there is no fact about whether it is correct?

If ethical disagreements are problematic for the intuitionist because they suggest that intuition is unreliable, then disagreements in metaethics are equally problematic for *any* metaethicist because they suggest that philosophical reflection and reasoning—or whatever methods metaethicists have been using—are unreliable. Many of the central ideas and arguments in the field have been around for decades, and philosophers have yet to agree on their soundness.

c) *The problem of resolving disagreement:* Similarly, if the intuitionist lacks an effective method for resolving ethical disputes, we all lack an effective method for resolving metaethical disputes. Again, the methods actually employed by philosophers have so far proved no more successful in resolving metaethical issues than they have in resolving ethical issues.

One reason for this is that the choice of a philosophical theory generally depends on broad judgments of overall plausibility made in the light of numerous inconclusive arguments, the relationship of the theory to other philosophical theories, and the various 'theoretical advantages' and disadvantages of competing views.²⁸ I see no alternative to this approach, but it means that most major philosophical disputes are unlikely to be resolved in the foreseeable future.

How should we react to the phenomenon of disagreement in philosophy? One might justifiably conclude that philosophical knowledge is very difficult to attain and that very little of it has been attained. One might thus be moved to take a hesitant and modest attitude towards one's philosophical beliefs. What one should not say—not just because it would be self-defeating, but because it is evidently false—is that we lack the cognitive faculties required for approaching philosophical questions. However difficult they may be and however prone we may be to error, we are not simply *closed off* to philosophical questions (in the sense in which my cat is)—we understand them and can make rational arguments about them. Intuitionism's opponents do not deny this; if they did, they would not engage in philosophical discourse. Similarly, a modest attitude

towards controversial moral beliefs is supported by the phenomenon of moral disagreement; what is not warranted is a denial that moral questions have answers or that we have the cognitive faculties for approaching them.

6.6 Disagreement as an argument for realism

The argument from disagreement is typically advanced by anti-realists. But for the reasons we have seen, the phenomenon of disagreement provides no significant evidence for their view. In fact, I shall now argue that disagreement is more of a problem for *anti*-realists than it is for realists.

6.6.1 Can anti-realists explain disagreement?

To start with, how can anti-realists explain why we argue with others about moral issues, asserting them to be mistaken, and so on? We have already seen the difficulties for subjectivists (chapter 3): According to individualist subjectivism, you can't disagree with someone's moral claim unless you think he's falsely reporting his own feelings. According to cultural relativism, you can't disagree with someone's moral claim unless you think he's wrong about what his society's customs are. It is hard to see why there should be widespread, unresolvable disputes about what our emotions or conventions are. On a non-cognitivist view, there aren't even any propositions to disagree about. People *can* have 'conflicting attitudes'²⁹—but this would not explain why, for example, one would try to *reason with* opponents of euthanasia or tell them they are *mistaken*. One does not normally argue with people or tell them they are 'mistaken' merely because they have different feelings from one's own.

Consider three replies to this. *First*: Perhaps we argue about moral issues because we mistakenly *think* moral realism is true. This reply works for nihilists. It does not work for subjectivists or non-cognitivists. Our belief in objective values only explains our arguing about moral questions if we take moral terms to refer to those objective value properties. But the subjectivist or non-cognitivist thinks moral language does not refer to any alleged objective properties but only expresses or reports subjective mental states. This leaves them with the bizarre idea that almost everyone is fundamentally wrong about the meanings of common words in our language and that, although we believe in objective value properties, we don't have any words for them.

Second: Perhaps our arguments about moral issues do not concern *fundamental* value judgments; what we're arguing about is really only

the non-moral facts that moral judgments depend upon. For instance, perhaps those who disagree about whether euthanasia is permissible really just disagree about the effects that allowing euthanasia would have. But this reply surrenders the fundamental premise of the argument from disagreement—namely, that there are widespread, fundamental moral disputes.

Third: Perhaps we argue about moral issues in an effort to change others' non-cognitive attitudes, not to change their beliefs. But we don't try to change others' attitudes by merely emoting at them; when we argue with others about morality, we say and think that they are *mistaken*, and we purport to give them intellectual reasons for changing their minds. This could make sense on an anti-realist view only if we think others are mistaken about some non-moral facts that their moral attitudes depend upon. In that case, argumentation could hope to change others' attitudes by correcting their mistaken factual assumptions. But again, this requires that moral disagreements fundamentally derive from mistakes about non-moral matters, contrary to the assumption of the argument from disagreement.

Non-cognitivists and subjectivists are, therefore, in no position to press the intuitionist's alleged inability to explain moral disagreement; moreover, to the extent that we are convinced that some moral disagreements really are fundamental, we have reason to reject non-cognitivism and subjectivism.

The situation for nihilists is more complex. They can explain moral disagreement by appealing to our widespread, mistaken belief in realism—but only if they can explain why people would make such an error. On the face of it, the simplest explanation for why nearly everyone thinks moral realism is true, is that it *is* true. Nihilists have proposed alternate explanations,³⁰ but it would take us too far afield to discuss them; for now, then, let us allow that nihilists may be able to account for moral disagreement.

6.6.2 Can anti-realists resolve disagreements?

The most that anti-realists might claim is that intuitionists have no way to resolve *fundamental* moral disagreements—that is, moral disagreements that do not depend upon factual errors or errors in reasoning. Allegedly, intuitionists can only exhort interlocutors to concentrate harder on the moral issue, and perhaps hit them over the head. But what does the anti-realist have to offer? For anti-realists, there are no objective value facts; so when it comes to fundamental value disputes, there is nothing *cognitive* that we can do; all we can do is, perhaps, to cajole, threaten, or agree to disagree. (Nihilists just say

that *everyone* is wrong.) How is this supposed to be superior to ethical intuitionism, even on the least sophisticated interpretation of intuitionism?

It is at this point that anti-realists will express optimism about how much people really have in common and about how many moral disputes will turn out to depend on errors of fact and reasoning.³¹ But the grounds for thinking people to have fundamentally different sensibilities seem at least as strong as those for thinking people to have fundamentally different intuitions.

Most anti-realists would want to embrace the methods of contemporary ethics, just as most contemporary ethicists embrace anti-realism. Is this consistent? Current practice in moral philosophy includes:

- a) *Ubiquitous appeal to intuitions* (with or without using the word 'intuition'). Every moral argument employs one or more intuitions. Take Peter Singer's well-known argument for a strong obligation to assist the poor: he relies on the 'plausible principle' that if we can prevent something bad without sacrificing anything of comparable significance, we ought to do so. Not content with this, he appeals to a hypothetical example in which he passes by a child drowning in a shallow pond. Singer appeals to our moral intuition (what else can it be called?) that he is obligated to help the child.³² As this case shows, intuitions both about general principles and about particular cases are used.

How can an anti-realist accommodate this? The nihilist can have no truck with any of this, since he thinks the relevant moral statements are all false—unless, perhaps, he proposes to *reform* our moral language, so that we come to use it as the non-cognitivists or subjectivists think we do.

For the non-cognitivist, moral discourse only expresses our attitudes. For the subjectivist, it reports our attitudes. Either way, it would seem that the only cognitive task for a moral philosopher is to study our feelings, desires, and other attitudes. Perhaps it will be said that the arguments based on moral intuitions are simply in the service of that aim—Singer is just drawing to our attention that we in fact approve of acts of preventing-bad-things-without-sacrificing-things-of-comparable-significance, including such acts as removing drowning children from shallow ponds. Perhaps it is not *intuitions* that his argument relies on, but moral *emotions*.

This would be fine, were it not for the second feature of contemporary discourse in moral philosophy:

- b) *Criticisms of biases*. Sometimes it is argued that certain moral intuitions or beliefs are unreliable, since they are just due to our culture, our religion, or plain selfishness. Recall, for example, Singer's argument that our intuitions about infanticide are unreliable since they are just due to cultural programming.³³ Elsewhere, he has suggested that our belief in the superiority of the human species is due to selfishness and to religious teachings that reflect our self-interest.³⁴

This makes sense to a moral realist: if a moral belief is due to biases of a kind that in general frequently cause false beliefs, then that belief likely fails to correspond to the moral facts. But what should an anti-realist say? The notion of 'bias' presupposes realism—a bias is a desire, emotion, or other psychological state that tends to distort our perceptions, to lead us away from the truth. That presupposes that there is a truth independent of our perceptions. For a cultural relativist, Singer's argument concerning infanticide is worse than a *non sequitur*: his premise that our beliefs about infanticide are caused by cultural indoctrination would *prove those beliefs correct*, rather than undermining them as Singer assumes. Even for a subjectivist or non-cognitivist, our culture is just one more source of our moral emotions; on what grounds could moral reactions caused by it be considered 'incorrect'?³⁵ The same applies to the supposed bias due to self-interest: if self-interest colors our moral emotions, all that shows is that self-interest partly determines what is morally right or good.

Perhaps the anti-realist would say that once we realize what causes some of our moral emotions, we will lose those emotions. Perhaps when we realize that our horror at infanticide is culturally programmed, we will stop feeling it. Or perhaps not. If moral emotions were caused by putative perceptions of moral facts, or if there were some outside standard of 'appropriateness' of moral emotions, perhaps then we would lose our moral emotions on discovering their parochial source. But once we renounce the idea that there is any moral truth independent of our feelings, why should the unsurprising discovery that some of our moral emotions are caused by cultural conditioning undermine those feelings?

A third aspect of our moral discourse is closely related to the second:

- c) *Criticisms of moral intuitions based on other intuitions*. Peter Singer, again, has suggested that 'our intuitive judgments [about particular cases] are based on things that are obviously of no moral

significance at all'. For example, he thinks our intuitions are biased towards those who are physically closest to us (so that we think we have stronger obligations to people in our neighborhood, say, than to those on other continents). How does Singer know that physical proximity is not morally relevant? The answer seems to be that that is 'obvious' or 'self-evident'—in short, it is an intuition.³⁶

The intuitionist can understand this: intuitions are a fallible form of access to moral truth. We can correct errant intuitions by appeal to firmer and more reliable ones. But what should an anti-realist say?

A 'morally relevant' property is one that affects whether a thing is good, bad, right, or wrong. On the subjectivist or non-cognitivist view of morality, this can only mean a property that affects (a certain subset of) our attitudes. So if physical proximity really affects our moral attitudes as Singer says, then that just proves that physical proximity *is* morally relevant.

Perhaps it would be argued that what is moral is determined, not by our current attitudes, but by the attitudes we *would* have if we were to become fully informed and rational (removing all inconsistencies and factual errors from our minds, and so on; see above, section 3.5). It is plausible *on a realist view* that a fully rational person would not have the bias towards those physically close to him that Singer describes, since he would recognize it *as a bias*. But there appears nothing *inconsistent* in our having this attitude, nor does it depend on a factual error, nor does Singer attempt to argue that it does. So why should a rational anti-realist lose the attitude? The fact that Singer's argument is regarded as forceful by ethicists, rather than an obvious *non sequitur*, suggests that moral philosophers illicitly employ an intuitionist methodology while purporting to reject intuitionism.

Now here are some things that do not normally appear in the ethics literature:

- d) *Mere appeals to common practices.* Critics of the notion of animal rights do not, for example, argue that since eating meat is the custom around here, it is right. Nor do animal rights supporters take the widespread maltreatment of animals to refute their own moral views.
- e) *Mere appeals to the author's or audience's emotions and desires.* Abortion opponents do not, for example, say that abortion is wrong because they or their audience has sympathetic feelings about cute little fetuses. Abortion defenders do not argue that

abortion is not murder because abortion doesn't make them feel the way murder does.

- f) *Naked rhetoric.* Philosophers do not attempt to 'convince' their audience of their moral views by simply using emotionally charged language, telling tear-jerking stories, or directing demands at the audience.

If some form of subjectivism, relativism, or non-cognitivism is true, why shouldn't the above be the common practice?

Subjectivists and non-cognitivists would advise us to be more subtle than merely to make direct appeals to current attitudes in all cases; they would say that we need to do some reasoning to make sure our attitudes are consistent and rest on no factual errors. Perhaps that is what moral reasoning is about. This suggestion, however, bears little resemblance to actual moral reasoning, nor is it likely to succeed in resolving many disputes. Recall the suggestion discussed in section 3.3 that the practice of slavery was criticizable from within our culture because it was inconsistent with our custom of respect for persons in general: why shouldn't the slavery-advocate simply reply, 'No, we don't have a custom of respect for *all* persons. We have a custom of respect for *white* persons'? One may be tempted to object that this rests on an arbitrary distinction—but if what is morally arbitrary or significant is just determined by customs, then skin color *is* morally significant, in many cultures. Compare the idea, perhaps supported by Singer, that our failure to aid the Third World poor is inconsistent with our general sympathy for other people: why shouldn't one simply reply, 'No, I don't have a feeling of sympathy for *all* other people. I have a feeling of sympathy for *nearby* people, who belong to my social group'? Those replies would make sense if we were subjectivists or non-cognitivists—they should *at least* have an important place in the debate—but in fact no one makes replies of that kind.

I grant that there are cases in which we act inconsistently with our customs—a few people occasionally slurping directly from the bowl does not refute the claim that our custom is to eat soup with a spoon; those few people are just violating the custom. Similarly, people's occasionally maltreating blacks would not refute the claim that we have a custom of respect for persons in general. But if the members of a society *intentionally* and *routinely* maltreat members of a certain race, then we don't say that they have two customs: a custom of respect for all persons, plus a custom of disrespect for one race. We say they have a custom of respect for members of certain races and

not others. A similar point applies to individual attitudes as applies to customs.

The anti-realist does, in fact, have available methods of resolving moral disagreements. The anti-realist should be employing methods (d), (e), and/or (f). The intuitionist should be employing (a), (b), and (c). Almost no one would find the anti-realist's approach more attractive than the intuitionist's.

This concludes our treatment of the most popular objection to intuitionism. The widespread confidence that ethical disagreement provides an immediate refutation of intuitionism appears to rest on little more than caricatures of the theory, epistemological double standards, and disregard of the phenomena of disagreement and error outside of normative ethics. Intuitionists do not hold moral error to be impossible, ethics is far from the only area where we find persistent disagreements, and intuitionists can take moral errors to be caused by the same kinds of factors as cause mistakes in other areas. Nor are intuitionists at a loss for ways of trying to reduce moral disagreement; they can endorse the very argumentative strategies currently employed by moral philosophers, including strategies designed to identify which intuitions are most likely to be in error. Intuitionists cannot promise a swift resolution of most moral controversies, but nor can anyone else. Finally, the arguments against intuitionism based on disagreement could be made with at least equal force against other metaethical theories, yet only against intuitionism have they been considered persuasive. This suggests that the argument from disagreement has seemed plausible only because philosophers had already rejected intuitionism for other reasons.